

ingly intimidating and discouraging for inexperienced graduates trying to compete against multinational companies. But consider this quote by Donald Trump: "If you're going to be thinking, you may as well think big."

So the first step is always about your concept—your idea of what the enterprise will be about, what it should be, how it should develop its products, its cost points, how it should operate within its environment, etc. It is very important that you feel confident about your idea, as this will help you to work harder towards being successful. A good understanding of commerce will certainly help. And don't think about the big companies in the domain—just focus on your plan!

Where do you belong?

With over 25 years of industry experience, Ganapathy Subramaniam, ex-CEO of Cosmic Circuits and presently a consultant to many ESDM companies, shares his views, saying, "According to me, manufacturing, design and assembly within the field of electronics is largely a part of the ESDM (electronic system design & manufacturing) sector. Hence, the upcoming start-up firms that aim to concentrate on that domain may well be classified into two categories." He adds, "One is the highly innovative, global market kind of a company. These organisations come up with a brand new idea and commercialise it. The other type of company is one that builds something over an existing idea. Both the product and the market for it exist globally, and Indian start-ups localise the idea for the domestic market."

So first, engineers must decide which category they belong to. Subramaniam says, "I would, in all probability, counsel the student community to consider the first category because they are not confined to any boundaries or routine patterns initially, and they can start to create something world-class. The second option could be for people who might not have great innovative ideas but are talented and are willing to take the risk of investing. To be suc-



PCB designing

cessful with the second option, it does require expertise within the industry," he further adds.

The engineer with a plan

A business plan is one of the most important documents to have. It is definitely a crucial tool in attracting investors. Coming up with a business plan is of utmost importance, so that you understand exactly where you ought to be at a particular point in time and what you should be doing. V. Sunder, MD and CEO, Ma Foi Connecting Dots Advisory Pvt Ltd, has over 25 years of rich experience in the areas of banking, financial services, manufacturing, design and engineering services. He believes that having a business plan is critical, as it structures the entrepreneurs' thinking, prompts them to plan for the future and helps them ensure they have covered all the important areas. He says, "The plan can be broken down into a short-term and long-term plan, and aligned with the business goals."

Yes, money matters. So collect as much of capital as possible and use it wisely. You need to plan the financial aspects very thoroughly—how much money needs to go into which area, for instance. Be cautious, but don't be tongue-tied when it comes to making enquiries or speaking up when validating your ideas with industry experts or seniors. Don't give up if the business fails or doesn't work out as well as you

had expected. Learn from your mistakes and move on.

Vinay Chaddha has an interesting take on the capital required for starting a business in the field of electronics. He says, "All the entrepreneurs that I am aware of personally have started off with zero or negligible capital. There are customers willing to pay money, provided

they are satisfied with the quality of work. I have four freshers working with me, and I am ready to pay them—provided I am satisfied with the quality of work done by them." He adds, "In electronics, there is not much of an investment required. Consider the example of PCB designing. Almost every engineering graduate has a laptop and Internet connection. They can easily start to work from home."

Experience before entrepreneurship?

One issue that the graduating engineering students definitely lack is experience. Subramaniam says, "It isn't that they'll blindly start an organisation. But in India, a very small proportion of the companies started by the student community are successful and most of the failures are because of a lack of understanding. Students must first put in a lot of thought into their plan, asking themselves if it is sufficiently different from the competition to take it to a larger scale." At the same time, Subramaniam believes that the engineering students are the only ones who are going to come up with path-breaking ideas since they are not bound by any limitations. Hence, one thing that engineers should do if they're planning to opt for the first category of business is to validate their ideas with experienced people who have built successful firms and have a